



THE NAVAL LEGACY OF THE HANCOCK – HARRINGTON FAMILIES

A GENERATIONAL CHRONOLOGY (1918 – 2026)

A comprehensive historical record accounting the continuous military and civic service of Captain Robert Edward Hancock, Sr., CEC, USN and his descendants across four generations.



DEDICATION

This historical record is proudly dedicated
to the memory, valor, and enduring legacy of
CAPTAIN ROBERT EDWARD HANCOCK, SR., CEC, USN (RET.)
and
CAPTAIN DANIEL JOSEPH HARRINGTON III, USN (RET.)

Whose decades of pioneering service spanning World War I,
World War II, and the dawning of the Jet Age forged a foundation
of duty, honor, and sacrifice that directly guided
their descendants across four generations.

"To those who go down to the sea in ships,
And do business on great waters;
They see the works of the Lord,
And His wonders in the deep."
Psalm 107:23-24



GENERATION I: Captain Robert Edward Hancock, CEC, USN

- **Chronology:** Born October 28, 1888; passed away July 3, 1973, in Jacksonville, Florida (Age 84).
- **Resting Place:** Arlington National Cemetery (Section 2, independent site, full military honors).
- **Rank & Branch:** Captain (CAPT), United States Navy, Civil Engineer Corps (CEC).
- **Active Service Window:** April 1918 – 1947 (29 years of continuous service).
- **Early Commissions:** Appointed April 1918 as Lieutenant Junior Grade (LTJG); promoted to full Lieutenant (LT) by June 1919.

Engineering & Command Impact

Graduated from Worcester Polytechnic Institute (1915, B.S. in Electrical Engineering). Worked at Western Massachusetts Electric Company before enlisting. Attained rank of Captain in June 1942. Served as Officer in Charge of Construction (OICC) at Naval Air Station Floyd Bennett Field heading into 1943. Spearheaded the physical transformation of the airfield from New York City's first municipal airport into a vital wartime naval aviation asset.

Major CEC Engineering Achievements

- **The "C" Flag:** Received the Navy "C" Pennant for ashore construction excellence.
- **Contractor Management:** Supervised heavy civilian engineering firms (White Construction Co., Underpinning and Foundation Co., Riggs Distler & Co.) executing millions in infrastructure builds.
- **Wartime Footprint Expansion:** Worked around the clock lengthening runways for heavy bombers, erecting the B-M Seaplane Hangar, and building personnel quarters.
- **Inter-Family Connection:** Married Hazel Dunton Hancock. Their daughter, Joyce Hancock, married into the Harrington family, unifying the naval lines.



GENERATION II (A): Lieutenant Commander Robert Edward Hancock, Jr., USN (SC) — *Son*

- **Chronology:** Born May 3, 1921; passed away February 24, 1988.
- **Resting Place:** Arlington National Cemetery (Section 2), sharing a plot with his wife, Grace Aileen (Holton) Hancock.
- **Rank & Branch:** Lieutenant Commander (LCDR), United States Navy, Supply Corps (SC).
- **Service Eras:** World War II, Korean War conflict, and the Vietnam War era.
- **Active Polar Stationing:** Stationed on the Ross Ice Shelf, Antarctica, for a significant portion of 1957.

- **Mission Assignment:** Deployed under Operation Deep Freeze II. In March 1957, he stepped into the grueling billet of Relief Supply Officer for Little America V, taking over the station's entire consumable, fuel, and storage tracking under extreme polar isolation.

GENERATION II (B): CAPT Daniel Joseph Harrington III, USN (Ret.) — Son-in-Law

- **Chronology:** Known affectionately as “Dan,” he married Captain Hancock's daughter, Joyce Hancock, in 1943.
- **Dates of Active Duty:** June 2, 1938 – July 1, 1968 (30 years active; 34 years total continuous service including 4 years as a USNA Midshipman from 1934 to 1938).
- **Naval Aviator Designation:** March 26, 1941 (Certificate Number 7170).
- **Total Flight Hours:** 3,070 career flight hours (Jet: 50, Propeller: 3,010, Helicopter: 10).
- **Flight Hours by Mission:** Fighter/Attack (VF/VA): 3,000, Transport/Patrol (VR/VP): 50, Helicopter Antisubmarine/Combat Support: 10, Lighter-Than-Air (LTA): 10.
- **Carrier Landings:** 50 successful fixed-wing aircraft carrier landings.
- **Combat Missions:** Flew 100 total combat missions during World War II.
- **Combat Tours:** VO onboard USS *Colorado* (1942–1943); VB-5 onboard USS *Yorktown* (1943–1944).
- **Formally Held Commands:** Senior Aviator attached to USS *Colorado* (1941–1943); CO of Bombing Squadron Five (VB-5) onboard USS *Yorktown* (1943–1944); CO of Naval Air Facility (NAF) China Lake, CA (1951–1953); CO of Naval Air Station (NAS) Whiting Field, FL (1957–1959).
- **Awards & Decorations:** Presidential Unit Citation (PUC) with multiple inclusive combat windows; Distinguished Flying Cross (2 awards); Air Medal (3 awards); Asiatic-Pacific Campaign Medal with multiple intense combat stars.
- **Significant Career Milestones:** Logged into federal naval history as **Early Jet Pilot Number 25** (initial flight Nov 1, 1944, at NATC Patuxent River in a twin-engine Bell YP-59A Airacomet); Experimental Test Pilot (1945–1947); Force Operations Officer at COMNAVAIRLANT.

Operational Narrative & Leadership Milestones

- **Pre-War Surface Duty & The "Two-Year Fleet Rule" (1938–1940):** Graduated (four years) USNA in June 1938. Mandated by rigid policy to serve two years surface duty before flight training. Assigned as an Ensign to the original commissioning crew of the cruiser USS *Nashville* (CL-43) under Capt William W. Wilson. Transferred to sister ship USS *Phoenix* (CL-46) in October 1938 to establish operational routines. Transited the West Indies, shifted homeports to San Pedro, and ultimately deployed to Pearl Harbor, promoting to LTJG.
- **Flight Training Pipeline (1940–1941):** Detached from USS *Phoenix*, promoted to LT, and passed elimination training in Consolidated NY-1 and N2S Stearman biplanes. Earned his Wings of Gold at NAS Pensacola on March 26, 1941.

- **WWII Combat (USS *Colorado*):** On the day of the Pearl Harbor attack, the battleship was undergoing shipyard overhauls at Puget Sound. He immediately returned to San Pedro from leave in Reno, flying back and landing safely despite a total coastal blackout. As Senior Aviator, he flew anti-submarine sweeps in a Vought OS2U Kingfisher floatplane launched via mechanical catapults, executing high-risk open ocean recoveries.
- **Command of VB-5 (*Yorktown*):** Joined USS *Yorktown* (CV-10) in May 1943. Witnessed Capt Joseph J. "Jocko" Clark's aggressive Norfolk departure where the accommodation ladder was torn from the hull. As CO of VB-5, he led Douglas SBD-5 Dauntless dive-bombers through 100 combat missions. During Operation Hailstone (Feb 16–17, 1944), he led the surprise destruction of the Japanese stronghold at Truk Atoll, bringing the entire squadron home with zero fatalities. His first child, Karen, was born March 19, 1944, while *Yorktown* was anchored at Espiritu Santo.
- **Pioneering the Jet Age:** Following an unauthorized qualification flight walkthrough in a Bell YP-59A Airacomet, his qualification was officially logged, making him the 25th military jet pilot. Logged 50 specialized jet hours at Patuxent River (1944–1946) establishing safety profiles for the Navy's first experimental jet airframes.
- **The "Titivate" Routine:** Frequently shared stories centered around the traditional naval term "titivate" (meaning to tidy up), referencing OPNAVINST 1640.8A as a reminder of naval discipline brought home to his family.
- **Inter-Generational Lemoore Context:** In April 1969, his sons Robert and Dan IV had a brief, isolated rendezvous at NAS Lemoore while Dan IV was training for fleet squadron assignment.
- **Family Composition:** Built a tightly knit family of five children (three boys, two girls) with his wife Joyce, framing a widespread legacy of Pacific Fleet operational service.

GENERATION II (C): Hazel Loretta Hancock (Delk) — Daughter-in-Law

- **Chronology:** Born 1912 in Moultrie, Colquitt, GA; died 1984 in Jacksonville, Florida.
 - **Marriage:** Married LCDR Robert Edward Hancock, Jr., USN (SC) in May 1960 as his second wife.
 - **Military Service:** Part of the pioneering generation of Navy Nurses who served during World War II and the Korean War era. Retired at senior officer rank after managing critical triage, overseas hospital ships, and domestic recovery wards.
 - **1947 Texas City Disaster Relief:** As a Lieutenant (Lt.) in the Navy Nurse Corps, she provided firsthand medical first-aid and treated casualties during the massive, non-nuclear ammonium nitrate cargo explosion of the SS *Grandcamp*, which killed at least 581 people.
 - **Resting Place:** Arlington National Cemetery (Section 2), sharing a final resting place with her husband.
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GENERATION III (A): LCDR Daniel Joseph Harrington IV, **USN — *Grandson***

- **Chronology:** Born July 25, 1945, in Annapolis, Maryland.
- **Service Window:** June 7, 1967 – June 30, 1987 (20 years, 0 months, 24 days of net active service).
- **Rank & Designation:** Lieutenant Commander (LCDR, pay grade O-4), Unrestricted Line Officer and designated Naval Aviator (Wings of Gold). Permanent rank advancement effective October 1, 1976.
- **Education & Airframes:** Graduated USNA on June 7, 1967. Flew the T-2 Buckeye, TA-4J/A-4F/A-4E Skyhawk, and LTV A-7 Corsair II. Executed 245 combat missions in Vietnam and accumulated 450 carrier flight deck landings.
- **Specialty Numbers:** Primary Billet Code 8926 (Target Aircraft Controller); Billet Code 8656 (Aviation Safety Officer, graduated Navy Aviation Safety Officer School, July 1972); Billet Code 2615 (Administration Officer, completed LMET in June 1971 and November 1979).
- **Advanced Tactical Pipelines:** Completed Weapons Loading Officer Light Attack Jet course (LOAJ, June 1970); graduated Navy Fighter Weapons School (TOPGUN) Adversary Pilot Course (September 1978); completed Navy Light Attack Weapons School curriculum (August 1980).

Commissioning, The Vietnam Pipeline & The Tuttle Bond

- **The "Joint Enlistment" Origins:** Career intertwined with classmate Robert Ervin Tuttle. On July 25, 1962, a historic joint swearing-in ceremony took place in assignment at Pensacola, where their fathers, CAPT Daniel J. Harrington III (Chief of Staff for Basic Air Training) and RADM Magruder H. Tuttle administered the oath of enlistment, preserved in the feature "Joint Enlistment in Style".. This ceremony marked their formal induction into the naval officer candidacy pipeline track.
- **Annapolis to Tip of Spear:** Following his preparatory tracking, Daniel IV entered the physical gates of Annapolis in July 1963. Both he and Robert Tuttle graduated together with the USNA Class of 1967. Daniel IV qualified in tactical jets, while Robert Tuttle answered the call of the U.S. Marine Corps as an infantry officer.
- **A Brother-in-Arms' Ultimate Sacrifice:** On May 8, 1968, during his first combat tour in Quang Nam Province, Second Lieutenant Robert E. Tuttle, USMC, was killed in action. This tragic loss permanently echoed across both families (Vietnam Veterans Memorial Wall, Panel 57E, Line 11).

Carrier Combat, Testing Operations & Family Reunions

- **VA-55 "Warhorses" Carrier Combat:** Assigned as fleet attack pilot out of NAS Lemoore flying the Douglas A-4F Skyhawk. Deployed to the Gulf of Tonkin aboard USS *Hancock* (CVA-19), targeting precise tactical destruction via dive-bombing, rockets, and missiles, while maintaining readiness for Nuclear Attack execution profiles.
- **Enlisted NAS Lemoore Rendezvous (April 1969):** Joined by his younger brother, Robert, who visited for a single day while on leave during his transition to an enlisted sailor. This prompted Robert to request brother-duty and secure orders to VA-56 that summer.

- **War-Zone Rendezvous (May 1970):** While USS *Hancock* was anchored at Subic Bay, his brother Robert flew out via helicopter from the newly arrived USS *America* (CVA-66). Daniel IV navigated a uniform snag (Robert was in working dungarees instead of mandated Dress Whites) to escort his brother down the ladder for safe passage.
- **VX-5 China Lake (1971–1974):** Served as NATOPS Training Officer at NAF China Lake, overseeing flight safety and pilot certifications. Flew high-stress test profiles on A-4 Skyhawk and LTV A-7 Corsair II systems, field-verifying weapon fuses, rockets, cluster bombs, laser guidance systems, and gun pods.
- **Three-Generation Flight Convergence (1971):** While Robert was a naval reservist with VF-301, he used an active ejection seat qualification to ride as a passenger in a dual-control Douglas TA-4J Skyhawk piloted by Daniel IV over high-desert ranges. Their father, CAPT Daniel J. Harrington III (Ret.), watched from the flight line below.
- **USS *Kitty Hawk* (CV-63) Assignment & Injury (1974–1976):** Served on the flight deck as a Catapult and Arresting Gear Officer. Suffered a severe herniated disc on the active flight deck in 1976, requiring major back surgery when the carrier transited into dry dock at Bremerton.
- **Keyport Torpedo Station Shore Duty (1976–1977):** Assigned to Keyport, Washington, for medical recovery, focusing on undersea weapon system logistics and ordnance verification.
- **Attack Squadron 127 (VA-127) Tour (1977–1980):** Served as a specialized Adversary Pilot for Dissimilar Air Combat Maneuvering (DACM), executing advanced air combat instruction and piloting tactical aircraft configured as an enemy "bogey". Graduated from the internally run Adversary Pilot Course taught by TOPGUN staff.
- **May 1980 NAS Lemoore Convergence:** Robert adjusted a cross-country drive with his sons Sean and Patrick to stop at NAS Lemoore during Daniel IV's active squadron birthday festivities. Robert famously spent the afternoon physically pushing his son Sean for a full kilometer to master riding his bike.
- **Attack Squadron 195 (VA-195) Fleet Tour (1980–1983):** Operated the A-7E Corsair II with Carrier Air Wing 11 aboard USS *America* (CV-66) under a primary mandate of Nuclear Attack. Directly opposed aggressive Libyan pilots, conducted defensive maritime patrols against hostile Iranian forces, and trained the Omani Air Force during a Suez Canal transit in May 1981.
- **VC-5 Command/Adversary Operations (1983–1985):** Oversaw specialized flight operations and advanced training out of NAS Cubi Point, Philippines. Provided realistic combat instruction to Pacific Fleet, USAF, and allied international pilots.
- **Subic Bay Aircraft Accident & Shasta Reunion:** On May 24, 1984, while conducting flight operations out of NAS Cubi Point, his TA-4J Skyhawk suffered a catastrophic jet engine failure over water. LCDR Harrington successfully executed a high-stakes low altitude emergency ejection and was recovered completely uninjured. Tragically, his back-seat pilot, LTJG Charles Richard Dickinson, was killed on impact with the water during the mishap sequence. Two days later (May 26), his brother Robert arrived on scheduled leave prior to assuming OIC duties for COMSPECWARGRU Det Alpha and found him safe at home recovering from the incident.

- **PMRF Barking Sands, Kauai (Final Tour 1985–1987):** Served as Senior Range Operations Officer, coordinating electronic threat simulation profiles across thousands of square miles of airspace. Directed the engineering modification of a Beechcraft Super King Air to retrofit it with a radar jammer and chaff dispensers.
- **The Pearl Harbor Convergence & Retirement:** On Sunday, February 1, 1987 (Pro Bowl weekend), he met face-to-face at Pearl Harbor with his brother Robert (who was transiting for Special Weapons Security Training on Ford Island). Honorably released from active duty on June 30, 1987, permanently establishing his home at 1125 Wiget Lane, Walnut Creek, CA.

Comprehensive Core Decorations

Navy Commendation Medal with Combat "V" Device (4th Award);

Air Medals (for 245 tactical carrier combat missions);

Navy Expeditionary Medal (USS *Kitty Hawk*);

Armed Forces Expeditionary Medal (USS *Hancock*);

Vietnam Service Medal with 4 Bronze Campaign Stars;

Republic of Vietnam Campaign Ribbon;

Republic of Vietnam Gallantry Cross with Gold Star;

Republic of Vietnam Air Gallantry Cross with Palm Unit Citation;

Meritorious Unit Commendations (VA-55, VX-5, and twice for USS *Kitty Hawk* flight deck crew);

Navy Expert Rifleman Medal;

Navy Expert Pistol Shot Medal.



GENERATION III (B): LT Robert Hancock Harrington, USN — Grandson

- **Chronology:** Born August 3, 1950, in the Naval Hospital, NAS Kodiak, Kodiak, Alaska.
- **Service Window:** November 7, 1967 – December 31, 1989 (22 years of total continuous naval history).
- **Rank & Designations:** Lieutenant (LT, pay grade O-3E), Unrestricted Line Officer and designated Surface Warfare Officer (SWO). Permanent rank advancement effective April 1, 1982.
- **Enlisted Technical Advancement:** Progressed through aviation fire control deckplates from Airman (AN) to AQF3, AQF2, and attained senior technical rank of Aviation Fire Control Technician First Class (AQ1 / E-6) on May 16, 1975.
- **Education:** USNA Midshipman (June 26, 1968 – April 11, 1969); graduated with a B.S. in Electronic Engineering from Cal State Pomona University (1975); graduated

Officer Candidate School (OCS) Newport, Class of March 1978; completed Surface Warfare Officer School (16 weeks, March 1978); completed LMET (November 1981); earned an M.S. in Information Systems from Strayer University (March 1993).

- **Primary Specialty Codes:** Primary Designator Code 1110 (Certified Surface Warfare Officer); Specialty Code 9555 (Naval Courier); Specialty Code 9279 (Officer in Charge of Tactical Combat Craft).
- **Assigned Units:** USNA, VA-56 "Champions" (USS *Ranger*), VA-146 "Blue Diamonds" (USS *America*), VF-301 "Devil's Disciples" (NAS Miramar), NAS Los Alamitos, NARU NAS Alameda, NETC Newport, USS *Ranger* (CV-61), USS *Shasta* (AE-33), Special Boat Unit Eleven (SBU-11) in Mare Island, Special Warfare Group One (SWG-1) Detached to Subic Bay, and Nuclear Weapons Training Group, Pacific.

Service Narrative & Billet History

- **USNA and Early Separation (1967–1969):** Enlisted under a 2x6 Delayed Enlistment on November 7, 1967. Secured an appointment to the U.S. Naval Academy, entering on June 26, 1968. Separated on April 11, 1969, due to an academic deficiency in French. Upon separation, his midshipman appointment was terminated and he was cleanly discharged back to the U.S. Naval Reserve to honor his initial enlistment contract. He completed formal ejection seat training at NAS Miramar during this window to secure an orientation flight in a TA-4J Skyhawk with VA-126.
- **Enlisted Lemoore & Aviation Pipeline (1969):** Reunited with Dan IV at Lemoore in April 1969, prompting him to request brother-duty. Assigned to VA-56 "Champions," completing TAD to the station galley and USS *Ranger* wardroom during carrier qualifications. Transferred to VA-146 "Blue Diamonds" in Fall 1969.
- **Enlisted Deckplates & Caribbean Operations (Early 1970):** Assigned to the beach detachment for Operation Springboard in Cuba and Puerto Rico, managing flight line galleys at Guantanamo Bay and Roosevelt Roads. Consolidated onboard USS *America* before transiting to Mayport in March 1970 for return to NAS Lemoore.
- **Pre Vietnam Diversion (1970):** Deployed with VA-146 to USS *America*. Enroute to the anticipated intense operational tempo of the Vietnam deployment, the USS *America* was briefly diverted by the ancient maritime tradition of the Line-Crossing ceremony on April 24, 1970, at 40° W longitude. This evolution presented a stark structural contrast across the flight deck: while the raucous, primal chaos of the Solemn Mysteries of the Ancient Order of the Deep played out among the crew, the absolute gravity of the war zone was displaced for a few hours. Heavily armed Marine sentries maintained a constant, unyielding guard over highly classified jet engine transport containers, inside of which lay hidden the specialized, corrosive line-crossing sludge prepared for the uninitiated Wogs. The juxtaposition of lighthearted, centuries-old naval folklore occurring directly alongside the rigid security of real-world tactical assets perfectly encapsulated the dual reality of life at sea.
- **Vietnam Deployment (1970):** Deployed to the Gulf of Tonkin as an enlisted Airman with VA-146 onboard USS *America*. Served in the scullery and ship's laundry before becoming an Operations Yeoman. Participated in Commando Tiger exercises in the Sea of Japan. Sought a helicopter flight out to USS *Hancock* in May 1970 to visit his brother. Released from active duty as an Airman (AN/E-3, Ordnance Mechanic) on November 27, 1970.
- **Reserve Component & Advanced Pipeline (1970–1971):** He was administratively transferred to the Naval Reserve Manpower Center in Bainbridge, Maryland and

directly assigned to the NAS Miramar reserve airwing. While in an inactive reserve status, he was promoted to AQF3 with VF-301, earning qualifications as an Airborne Systems Control Unit (ASCU) and Tactical Computer IMA Technician.

- **The TAR Career and Advanced Computing (1971–1976):** Reenlisted into active duty under the Training and Administration of the Reserves (TAR) program on September 21, 1971. Attended advanced computing avionics "B" school at NATTC Memphis, advancing to AQF2. Upon completion of his technical training, he returned directly to the fleet at NAS Miramar to resume operational aviation duties. While stationed at Miramar, he was selected for the prestigious Navy Scholarship Program. This milestone triggered his transfer to NAS Los Alamitos, where he utilized his scholarship at Cal Poly Pomona and successfully graduated with a B.S. in Electronic Engineering in 1975. While attached to Los Alamitos, his technical expertise and leadership were recognized with a promotion to the senior technical rank of Aviation Fire Control Technician First Class (AQ1 / E-6) on May 16, 1975. After completing his scholarship program, he was retained on active duty at NAS Los Alamitos before being transferred to the NART) at NAS Alameda for duty. He was awarded his first Navy Good Conduct Medal in September 1976
- **Naval Air Reserve Training Detachment (NARTD) Alameda to OCS Newport (1976–1977):** Ordered to NARU NAS Alameda to instructor duty for reserve education pipelines, earning his first Navy Good Conduct Medal in September 1976. He maintained full active duty TAR status until entering OCS in late 1977.
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- **USS *Ranger* Wardroom Irony & Leadership (1977–1981):** Accepted into Officer Candidate School in Newport, Rhode Island, entering in November 1977. Formally discharged from the enlisted ranks to accept his commission, graduating as an Ensign on March 17, 1978. In a profound demonstration of fleet irony, his subsequent orders directed him to report directly to the wardroom of the USS *Ranger* (CV-61)—the exact same aircraft carrier where, a mere decade prior, he had performed the grueling, unglamorous deckplate routines of an enlisted mess-cook. This transition from the lower decks to the officer country brought with it a distinct, dual perspective on shipboard life.
- **USS *Ranger* vs MS *Fortune Monrovia*:** When the catastrophic collision with the tanker *Fortune Monrovia* compromised the vessel's hull integrity in the narrow, high-traffic channels of the Straits of Malacca on April 5, 1979, this deep structural familiarity proved invaluable. Assigned to the engineering department and entrusted as the Assistant Damage Control Assistant, he stood upon the very deckplates he had once scoured, now directing the high-stakes fire boundary teams and structural shoring details that successfully contained the flooding, stabilizing the massive carrier through an acute maritime crisis. Later served as the OE Division Officer managing air search radars. Promoted to Lieutenant Junior Grade (LTJG) during this tour.
- **May 1980 Lemoore Convergence:** Visited his brother Dan IV while on leave from USS *Ranger*, participating in squadron birthday festivities and pushing his son Sean for a full kilometer to master his bicycle.
- **The Ammunition Deck & Underway Logistics (1981–1983):** Cross-decked in April 1981 in Subic Bay to report to the ammunition ship USS *Shasta* (AE-33) as Electronic Material Officer (EMO), earning his Surface Warfare Officer (SWO) designation. In

May 1981, assisted in the emergency blue-water recovery of 298 fleeing Vietnamese and Cambodian refugees in the South China Sea, safely delivering them to Singapore.

- **The Arabian Sea Lifeline & Al Masirah Logistics (Summer 1981):** While operating on extended line-periods in the North Arabian Sea and Gulf of Oman—famously designated as "Gonzo Station"—the Kilauea-class ammunition ship USS Shasta (AE-33) served as an unrelenting logistics anchor for the battle group under Ltjg Harrington's electronic material and safety watch. Amidst the grueling months of blue-water steaming, the ship frequently conducted critical airhead and vertical replenishment operations, coordinating troop and personnel transfers (v/v) alongside high-priority cargo airlifts routed through the austere desert airfield at Al Masirah, Oman.
- **Deck Department Head (First LT):** LT Robert H. Harrington was promoted to the rank of full Lieutenant on April 1, 1982. In June 1982, CDR John Kipp relieved the assigned ship's First Lieutenant of duty due to an administrative Personnel Reliability Program disqualification, leaving an immediate vacancy ahead of the 1982–1983 Western Pacific cruise. Bypassing the standard department head school pipeline, CDR Kipp appointed him to fill the breach. He was officially thrust into the demanding billet of First Lieutenant for the ammunition ship USS Shasta (AE-33). This atypical placement placed the entirety of the ship's Deck Department under his direct watch, requiring the immediate mastery of complex underway replenishment architectures and the safe stowage of multiple types of ordnance without a safety net. Concurrently assigned as the vessel's Nuclear Safety Officer, he carried the immense dual burden of managing heavy, highline logistics over open ocean swells while enforcing absolute, unyielding compliance with sensitive ordnance handling protocols—a level of command trust rarely extended to an officer without formal institutional department training.
- **Portland Rose Festival (1982):** Successfully navigated heavily ash-choked Columbia River channels following the 1980 Mt. St. Helens eruption to participate in the 74th Annual Portland Rose Festival (June 4–13, 1982).
- **USS *Enterprise* Rearming:** In mid July 1982, tasked to onload the entire missile/bomb loadout at NWS Concord and the next day offload it at NAS Alameda directly across the pier to USS *Enterprise*.
- **The Mission Swap & NorPac Cruise (Sept 1982 – April 1983):** Mid-transit from San Francisco to Hawaii, *Shasta* swapped missions with USS *Sacramento* (AOE-1), assuming a grueling Western and Northern Pacific profile. Logistical operations were reinforced by HC-11 Det 1 operating two HH-46A Sea Knight helicopters. This grueling push culminated in a strategic, fuel-critical port entry into Naval Air Facility (NAF) Adak, Alaska. Safely guided alongside the rugged cargo pier at Adak, the *Shasta* moored directly with the guided missile destroyer USS *Goldsborough* (DDG-20). The port call served as a vital operational window to coordinate deep-water logistics, weapon security tracking, and regional transit routing before navigating back into the storm-heavy swells of the North Pacific.

Throughout the grueling sub-arctic transit, the substantial cargo capacities of the USS *Shasta* permitted the ammunition ship to consume a mere six percent of its expansive 600,000-gallon DFM reserve daily, rendering it an unrelenting logistics anchor for the battle group. Conversely, the older, high-pressure steam plant of their single-screw frigate escort possessed restrictive

bunker limits that consumed approximately thirty percent of its total fuel volume every twenty-four hours while battling the punishing Pacific head-seas. To sustain this vulnerable combatant, the *Shasta* operated as its primary refueling platform. By rigging a tensioned span-wire from the aft starboard refueling station, the *Shasta* utilized its massive displacement to effectively flatten the churning wake swells behind its hull, engineering a stable hydrodynamic pocket that allowed the escort's helmsman to safely lock into formation and receive the critical fuel lifeline.

Managed continuous fleet rearmaments through Hawaii, two stops at Adak, Subic Bay, Guam, Pattaya Beach, Hong Kong, Inchon, Chinhai, Okinawa, Sasebo, and Yokosuka.

- **Special Warfare Command (Dec 1983 – Feb 27, 1986):** Transitioned into tactical combat craft operations at Mare Island as a designated Small Craft Officer. splitting into two fields:
 - *Special Boat Squadron One, Det Alpha (June 1984 – Dec 1984):* Served as Officer in Charge (OIC) of Special Boat Squadron One, Detachment Alpha out of Subic Bay from June to December 1984, focusing on theater security and counter-piracy. Deployed his detachment and 36-foot Special Warfare Craft–Light (SWCL) "Sea Fox" to Auckland, New Zealand, via C-141 for a joint tri-nation ANZUS military exercise, earning a Navy Meritorious Unit Commendation. Completed MAC Affiliation Airlift Planners Course and Political Warfare Studies. Profoundly relieved to find his brother Dan IV safe on May 26, 1984, following Dan's emergency ejection.
 - *Special Boat Unit Eleven (SBU-11) Command Tour:* Resumed duties with the "River Rats" directing PBR and Mini Assault Transport Craft (MATC) operations out of Mare Island. SBU-11 flawlessly executed two short-notice civic emergencies while sustaining readiness, earning a Navy MUC (Oct 12, 1985 – Feb 20, 1986): **The Sacramento River Delta Whale Rescue** (November 1985, tracking and herding a lost humpback whale out of agricultural waterways) and **The Russian River Flood Rescue Operations** (February 1986, launching craft into flooded Guerneville to rescue trapped civilians). *He was not part of the last as he was on 30 days leave in transit to NWTGP.*
- **Nuclear Weapons Training Group Pacific Shore Duty Instructor (1986–1989):** Reported February 28, 1986, as Surface Weapons Senior Safety Instructor at COMNUWPNTRAGRUPAC at NAS North Island. Developed core curriculum blueprints and safety frameworks across the Pacific Fleet, leveraging his expertise as a certified Nuclear Safety Officer, Radiological Controls Officer, and Nuclear Safety Administrator
- **The Final Operational Reunion (1987) & Retirement:** Met face-to-face at Pearl Harbor with his brother Dan IV on Sunday, February 1, 1987, while undergoing Special Weapons Security Training on Ford Island. Honorably released from active duty on December 31, 1989, processing through PSD North Island. His permanent military retirement became effective January 1, 1990, after successfully completing exactly 20 years, 0 months, and 17 days of net institutional active service..

Combat Awards, Decorations & Unit Citations

Navy Commendation Medal (awarded by COMNAVSURFPAC for outstanding performance as 1st LT and Nuclear Weapons Safety Officer on USS *Shasta*, establishing the training program that nuclear recertified the ship);

Meritorious Unit Commendations

First Award for saving USS *Ranger* after the *Fortune Monrovia* collision;

Second Award for SBU-11 emergency rescue and readiness metrics;

Navy Good Conduct Medal (September 1976);

Naval Reserve Meritorious Service Medal;

National Defense Service Medal;

Navy Expeditionary Medal (Iranian Hostage Crisis / North Arabian Sea aboard USS *Ranger*);

Armed Forces Expeditionary Medal (Commando Tiger exercises aboard USS *America*);

Vietnam Service Medal with 2 Campaign Stars;

Humanitarian Service Medal (for the blue-water rescue of 298 refugees on USS *Shasta*);

Sea Service Deployment Ribbon with 2 Bronze Stars;

Republic of Vietnam Campaign Medal;

Navy Expert Rifleman Medal;

Navy Expert Pistol Shot Medal.

- **Elite Warfare Insignia:** Authorized to wear the Surface Warfare Officer (SWO) breast insignia and the Small Craft Officer insignia.

Official Duty Assignment Chronology

- **07 Nov 1967 – 25 Jun 1968:** NAVRES DET 8-29, Carlsbad, NM (Seaman Recruit / Inactive Reserve)
- **26 Jun 1968 – 11 Apr 1969:** U.S. Naval Academy, Annapolis, MD (Midshipman / Active Duty)
- **29 May 1969 – 07 Oct 1969:** VA-56 "Champions", NAS Lemoore, CA | USS *Ranger* (Seaman Apprentice)
- **08 Oct 1969 – 27 Nov 1970:** VA-146 "Blue Diamonds", NAS Lemoore, CA | USS *America* Cruise (AQFAN)
- **28 Nov 1970 – 20 Sep 1971:** VF-301 "Devil's Disciples", NAS Miramar, CA (AQFAN/AQF3 / Inactive Reserve Window).

- **21 Sep 1971 – 20 Mar 1972:** Reenlisted active duty as TAR
- **21 Mar 1972 – 05 Sep 1972:** Naval Air Technical Training, Millington, TN (AQF3/AQF2 / Advanced Avionics "B" School)
- **06 Sep 1972 – 05 Mar 1973:** NAS Miramar, CA (AQF2 / Returned from NATTC for Fleet Duty & Scholarship Selection)
- **06 Mar 1973 – 05 Dec 1975:** NAS Los Alamitos, CA | Navy Scholarship Program (AQF2/AQ1 / Promoted to E-6 on 16 MAY 75 & Graduated Cal Poly Pomona)
- **06 Dec 1975 – 05 Jun 1976:** NAS Los Alamitos, CA (AQ1 / Remained on Active Duty (Post-Scholarship)
- **06 Jun 1976 – 05 Nov 1977:** NARTD, NAS Alameda, CA (AQ1 / Master Training Instructor, Final Enlisted Tour & Good Conduct Medal)
- **06 Nov 1977 – 16 Mar 1978:** NETC Newport, RI (Officer Candidate Student OCUI-1, Discharged from enlistment to accept Officer Commission)
- **17 Mar 1978 – 03 Aug 1978:** Surface Warfare Officer School, Coronado, CA (Ensign)
- **04 Aug 1978 – 13 Apr 1981:** USS *Ranger* (CV-61) | Assistant DCA / OE Division Officer (LTJG)
- **14 Apr 1981 – 16 Dec 1983:** USS *Shasta* (AE-33) | EMO | First Lieutenant (LTJG/LT / Promoted to O-3)
- **17 Dec 1983 – 27 Feb 1986:** Special Warfare Commands: OIC SBS-1 Det Alpha & Assault Craft Officer, SBU-11 (LT)
- **28 Feb 1986 – 31 Dec 1989:** COMNUWPNTRAGRUPAC, NAS North Island, CA (Surface Weapons Senior Safety Instructor / Retired)



GENERATION III (C): Robert Edward Hancock III, USMC (Ret.) — Grandson

- **Chronology:** Born May 18, 1944.
 - **Branch of Service:** United States Marine Corps / Marine Corps Reserve.
 - **Service Context & Retirement:** Carried the historic family name forward as the third consecutive generation of continuous military service, leading across active and reserve components. Officially transitioned to retired rolls upon reaching the standard age of 65 for Marine Corps Reserve personnel.
 - **Legacy Footprint:** Settled permanently in Jacksonville, Florida—the exact municipality where his grandfather, CAPT Robert E. Hancock, Sr., passed away in 1973.
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GENERATION III (D): HM2 Eugene Scott Hancock, USN — Grandson

- **Status:** Killed in Action (KIA); posthumous recipient of the Navy Cross and the Purple Heart.
- **Chronology:** Born June 20, 1946; killed in action February 24, 1969, at La Chau (2), Quang Nam Province, South Vietnam.
- **Resting Place & Memorials:** Arlington National Cemetery (Section 2, grave site near his father and grandfather). Permanently honored on the Vietnam Veterans Memorial Wall on Panel 31W, Line 54.
- **Warfare Branch:** Navy Hospital Corps / Fleet Marine Force (FMF).
- **Assigned Combat Unit:** Attached to Headquarters and Service Company, serving directly as a Line Combat Corpsman with Company I, 3rd Battalion, 7th Marine Regiment, 1st Marine Division (Reinforced), Fleet Marine Force.
- **Legacy Context:** First cousin to Robert Hancock Harrington and Daniel Joseph Harrington IV. Stepped onto the dangerous front lines as an elite, field-integrated Combat Corpsman under the highly respected title of "Doc," operating on the absolute tip of the spear.

The Enlistment Pipeline & Medical Training Tracks (1966–1967)

- **The Enlistment Framework:** Formally raised and educated in Florida, he graduated as a proud alumnus of Gainesville High School with the Class of 1964. Driven by a deep sense of family duty as the conflict in Southeast Asia escalated, he volunteered for service, officially enlisting in the United States Navy on November 14, 1966.
- **The Specialized Medical Track:** Upon successful completion of foundational naval training at Recruit Training Command, he was selected for the highly demanding medical pipeline, reporting to Basic Hospital Corps School at Great Lakes, Illinois. Here, he mastered the foundational elements of trauma care, triage management, and clinical military medicine, successfully graduating to earn his rating as a Navy Hospital Corpsman.
- **The FMF Crucible:** Recognizing his high physical readiness and absolute composure under stress, the Navy routed him into advanced tactical combat training at Field Medical Service School (FMSS) at Camp Lejeune, North Carolina. Immersed in Marine Corps small-unit tactics, field survival, and battlefield trauma life support, he successfully completed the grueling pipeline. This crucial milestone formally earned him his designation within the Fleet Marine Force (FMF), permanently weaving his naval rating into the combat ranks of the U.S. Marine Corps infantry tip of the spear.

The Action at La Chau (2) — Navy Cross Citation

On February 24, 1969, while conducting intensive search and destroy operations near La Chau (2) in the Quang Nam Province, Company I came under a sudden, devastating ambush by an entrenched North Vietnamese Army force. Disregarding the intense volume of incoming enemy fire, HM2 Hancock repeatedly moved across open ground to administer life-

saving medical aid to wounded Marines and drag them to safety. Exposing himself a final time to reach a critically wounded comrade in an open position, he was mortally wounded while rendering aid. His selfless valor and extraordinary heroism in the face of the enemy permanently crown the Hancock lineage with a legacy of absolute devotion to his brothers-in-arms.

GENERATION IV (A): LT Benjamin Stowe Harrington, USN — Great-Grandson

- **Rank/Name:** Lieutenant (LT), United States Navy.
 - **Education & Branch:** Attended the U.S. Naval Academy (USNA), entering the Yard in July 1996 and graduating with the millennium Class of 2000. He was commissioned directly into the Navy Supply Corps.
 - **Current Location:** Based locally in the Walnut Creek, California area.
 - **Corporate Career:** Transitioned into a professional career in the technology and electronics sector after fulfilling his mandatory active-duty naval service obligations.
 - **Legacy Context:** Grandson of CAPT Daniel J. Harrington III and Joyce Hancock. Carried the family name back to Annapolis, taking charge of vital logistics, operational readiness pipelines, and material asset infrastructure for the fleet until a severe back injury mandated the premature termination of his active commission.
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THE UNITED STATES COAST GUARD LINEAGE

(Connected via Generation II Baseline)

Captain Kenneth Farrington Bishop, USCG (Ret.) — Grandson-in-Law

- **Lineage Connection:** Married into the family via Joyce Hancock / Karen line.
- **Rank Attained:** Captain (O-6), projecting senior leadership across demanding maritime safety, environmental protection, and search-and-rescue (SAR) corridors.
- **Key Assignments:** Led high-stakes shore stations and major cutter platforms. Served with the U.S. Coast Guard in Alameda, California, focusing on marine safety, containment, and environmental response initiatives.
- **Historical Highlights:** In the mid-1980s, played an active public role in presenting and coordinating panel sessions concerning regional maritime oil-spill response plans and the commercial evaluation of advanced bilge water treatment equipment.

Commander Kelly Post (Bishop), USCG (Ret.) — Great-Granddaughter

- **Lineage Footprint:** Followed her father's footprints into the commissioned ranks of the United States Coast Guard, managing critical homeland security, law enforcement, and search-and-rescue response frameworks until her active retirement.

APPENDIX A: ADDITIONAL FAMILY HISTORICAL LORE AND OPERATIONAL CHRONICLES

The following narratives represent the ground-truth human reality of naval service and family life, preserved through third-person verbose accounts and shared sibling memories. These chronicles capture the unique humor, unexpected crises, and unmatched resilience that defined the Harrington family on the home front and on the active deckplates of the Pacific Fleet.

CHRONICLE I: THE COLD WAR "GOAT" OF CHINA LAKE (1951)

Following the birth of Lieutenant Robert Hancock Harrington, USN, in the sub-arctic environment of Kodiak, Alaska, the family executed a stark environmental transition when Captain Daniel J. Harrington III, USN, assumed command of Naval Air Facility (NAF) China Lake, California, in 1951. Managing four children under the age of seven years—Karen, Daniel IV, Bonnie, and newborn Robert—in the triple-digit desert heat, his mother, Joyce Harrington, utilized local ingenuity by placing young Robert in a secure chest harness attached to a tree in the yard via a length of rope. This arrangement safely restricted his movement while the household quarters were established. During a subsequent base-wide air raid siren activation, which ultimately proved to be a false alarm, the family conducted a rapid tactical scramble into designated shelter. In the ensuing chaos, the sibling head count was omitted, and the youngest child was inadvertently left outside. Upon the sounding of the "all clear" signal, the family returned to the yard to discover the future First Lieutenant remaining securely anchored to the tree, entirely undisturbed by the evolution.

CHRONICLE II: THE 15-MILE HEAD COUNT (CIRCA 1953)

During a subsequent cross-country logistical transfer from NAF China Lake to the Atlantic fleet hub of Norfolk, Virginia, the family stopped for fuel at a remote, two-lane highway service station. In the process of unloading and reloading the station wagon with four young children, a breakdown in internal communication occurred, wherein each parent operating the vehicle mistakenly assumed the other had secured the youngest toddler. The vehicle subsequently departed the pumps and transited a full 15 miles down the highway before a formal head count was initiated inside the cabin. Upon discovering the empty seat, a hasty turnaround was executed, resulting in a 30-mile round-trip panic back to the point of origin. Upon arriving back at the service station, the parents discovered young Robert sitting entirely alone and content on the asphalt directly adjacent to the gas pump, patiently holding his station until the return of his vessel.

CHRONICLE III: THE MASIRAH NAVY RELIEF FUNDRAISER (SUMMER 1981)

- **The Enterprise Special Procurement:** To ensure the sanctioned fundraiser generated maximum proceeds for the Navy Relief Society during these high-stress operations, Lieutenant Harrington coordinated a high-priority logistics transfer. Visiting the nuclear-powered aircraft carrier USS *Enterprise* (CVN-65) while in the operational area, he successfully procured choice high-end merchandise and ship's store stock to serve as premier prizes for the crew's charitable raffle.

- **The Charity Drive: Back onboard the *Shasta*, the mess decks were transformed into a vibrant fundraising hub featuring various games of chance and skill. The event was designed to boost morale and maximize contributions to the Navy Relief Society, resulting in a successful and memorable fundraising push under the scorching Indian Ocean sky.**

CHRONICLE IV: THE TROPICAL SUPPLY SCRAMBLE FOR ADAK (SEPTEMBER 1982)

While transiting from San Francisco to Hawaii in anticipation of a warm-weather deployment, the crew of the USS *Shasta* received sudden operational modifications diverting them north to assume the sub-arctic deployment profile of the fast combat support ship USS *Sacramento* (AOE-1). This rapid change in theater caught the ship's supply department unprepared, as naval supply nodes in Oahu did not possess winter apparel inventories for a crew configured for the tropics. Senior personnel initially advised the First Lieutenant that snow accumulation on the weather decks would not present an impediment, asserting that internal shipboard temperatures would adequately radiate upward to melt any frozen precipitation. This assessment proved inaccurate, as the heavily insulated ammunition spaces maintained freezing deckplates. Upon arrival at Naval Air Station Adak, Alaska, the crew systematically emptied the local Navy Exchange of all cold-weather apparel to outfit the line-handling teams. Despite operating in severe Aleutian gales with mismatched winter gear and a total absence of standard rock salt, the ice layer remained thin, and the Deck Department safely executed every high-stakes replenishment.

CHRONICLE V: REFUELING THE "SHORT-LEGGED" ESCORT

To ensure stable ordnance transfers, the actual highline operations were managed further south, where maritime temperatures hovered in the forty-degree range. Throughout the sub-arctic cruise, the USS *Shasta* was accompanied by an older, single-screw frigate/destroyer escort running on a high-pressure steam plant. Possessing restricted bunker capacities, this escort exhibited exceptionally "short legs," consuming approximately 30% of its total fuel volume per day while combating the heavy Pacific head-seas. Conversely, the substantial cargo capacity of the USS *Shasta* allowed the ammunition ship to consume a mere 6% of its 600,000-gallon DFM reserve daily. To sustain the escort, the *Shasta* operated as a primary refueling vessel, frequently rigging a tensioned span-wire from the aft starboard station. This specific tactical positioning effectively flattened the heavy wake swells behind the *Shasta*'s hull, providing the escort's helmsman with an optimal hydrodynamic pocket to lock into formation and receive necessary fuel transfers.

CHRONICLE VI: THE FIRST LIEUTENANT VS. THE MAYOR OF PORTLAND (JUNE 1982)

Prior to its deployment to the North Pacific, the USS *Shasta* demonstrated maritime versatility by successfully navigating the heavily ash-choked channels of the Columbia River following the cataclysmic eruption of Mount St. Helens, arriving to participate in the 74th Annual Portland Rose Festival from June 4 through June 13, 1982. As an authorized morale measure, crew members were permitted to transport their personal vehicles onboard the vessel. Upon mooring pier-side in Portland, the Deck Department initiated offloading operations, with First Lieutenant Harrington's vehicle being the first off the ramp. Remaining on the pier as the final officer to personally verify that every sailor's vehicle was safely accounted for, Lieutenant Harrington turned to discover that his own automobile had been

removed by a local towing company for allegedly parking in a restricted zone on the secure military pier. Moments later, as the Mayor of Portland arrived on the quarterdeck for the official welcoming reception, Lieutenant Harrington directly engaged the city's executive leader, stating that municipal hospitality had resulted in the removal of the ship's Department Head vehicle from a secure pier. The Mayor, recognizing the diplomatic embarrassment, directed his staff to immediately intervene, resulting in the safe return of the vehicle to the pier within two hours.

CHRONICLE VII: THE NIGHT RECOVERY AT SUBIC BAY (15 DECEMBER 1982)

The Watch Relief

The year was 1982, and the mid December tropical night outside of Subic Bay was as black as pitch. The sky was stripped of all moonlight, but blessed with an uncharacteristic, windless, glass-calm sea. The air was thick with the heavy, humid warmth of the Philippine Sea, smelling of salt water and marine fuel. On the bridge of the ammunition ship USS Shasta, the only sound was the deep, rhythmic hum of the steam turbines below. Lieutenant Robert Harrington had just formally assumed the watch as the Officer of the Deck (OOD), relieving Lieutenant Roger Stewart after hours of grueling underway replenishment (UNREP) operations.

The formal transition of watches is always a vulnerable, hyper-vigilant time for a warship. The outgoing team is exhausted, the incoming team is adjusting their night vision to the eerie red glow of the bridge tactical lights, and logs are being signed. Nothing in standard schoolhouse doctrine prepared Harrington for the sudden hydrodynamic crisis that erupted over the ship's internal communications just seconds into his watch.

The Crisis

The initial report crackled through the sound-powered headset to the lee helmsman, who broke the peaceful quiet like a gunshot—a chilling, breathless bark: "Man overboard, I think."

Sensing the critical missing technical elements of the puzzle, Harrington did not waste precious seconds. He immediately demanded the location, asking for the side. The tense voice over the sound-powered phones gave a singular, terrifying response that was relayed:

"In the middle."

It was the absolute nightmare scenario for a single-screw naval vessel. A "Man Overboard in the Middle" meant the victim had fallen from the extreme stern and was falling directly into the centerline slipstream of the ship's massive, rotating propeller. To make matters worse, neither the port nor starboard lookouts had the presence of mind to deploy their lighted casualty-marker life rings, and, unknown at the time, the off-going aft lookout lacked the gear entirely. The victim was somewhere in the pitch-black, warm tropical water with zero visual telemetry or strobe markers to track his position.

Tradition vs. Real-World Seamanship

Lieutenant Harrington did not hesitate. He immediately bellowed to the lee helmsman: "ALL STOP!"

The command would cause the engineering watch team to stop the turbine blades from spinning and that would cease the rotation of the shaft turning the ship's propeller before they could chop the sailor to pieces, allowing the ship's forward momentum to carry the stern safely past the casualty. Only after the deadly blades were neutralized did Harrington turn to his Watch Team and order the Boatswain's Mate of the Watch (BMOW) to pass the shipwide announcement. The piercing whistles of the Boatswain's pipe sliced through the night via the 1MC speakers, waking the sleeping crew to the terrifying words: "Man overboard, man overboard, this is not a drill!"

Harrington knew he had only minutes, and he understood the exact handling characteristics of his vessel. Waiting for the main engines to answer STOPPED, he then ordered: "ALL BACK FULL!"

To anyone unfamiliar with real-world seamanship, Harrington's choice to back down a warship during a man overboard was a radical departure from standard naval doctrine. Every young officer was taught that the correct, textbook response was a standardized tactical turn—specifically the "Buttonhook" or a Williamson Turn. These textbook maneuvers dictated putting the rudder over hard, swinging clear of the victim, looping around in a massive arc, and coming back down the original track line.

But standard doctrine assumed an unobserved fall, a massive search area, and an open ocean. Harrington recognized that at a slow five knots in the dead-calm waters outside of Subic Bay, executing a sprawling, miles-long tactical turn would consume precious time and actively pull the ship away from a known location. He chose immediate, precise ship-handling over the schoolhouse manual.

As the massive steam turbines answered the bells and drove the shaft in reverse, a violent, heavy shudder rippled forward through the steel spine of the ship. Up on the bridge, Harrington felt the deck plates vibrate intensely beneath his boots. This violent shuddering was the unmistakable physical signature of the single propeller fighting the sea. It told him exactly what he needed to know without looking: the screw was biting hard, the stern was actively walking heavily to port through transverse thrust—the classic paddle-wheel effect—and the massive steel bow was swinging to starboard. This crucial physical reaction pushed the steel hull safely away from the drop point, preventing the reversing ship from running the man down in its blind spot.

The Hydrodynamic Pocket

As the ship backed ceased all forward motion, Harrington ordered "ALL STOP" once more. His precision ship-handling had achieved the perfect tactical position. Behind the vessel, a churning, white-foamed wake expanded outward, but along the hull, the sheer physical mass of the vessel and its sudden backing momentum had broken the ocean's surface tension. It carved out a quiet, localized hydrodynamic "lee" pocket along the starboard hull. The victim, who happened to be an exceptionally strong swimmer, found himself trapped perfectly within this calm, protected starboard pocket, shielded by 500 feet of steel.

With the ship stabilized in its protective drift, the ship's Captain, Commander John Kipp, suddenly materialized on the bridge, his face tight with concern, closely followed by Lieutenant Stewart, who was rushing back to his man-overboard post. The initial shock of the emergency 1MC broadcast had brought the command team

to life. Recognizing that the critical ship-handling phase was complete and the ship was safely positioned, Harrington handed the watch back over to Stewart. Free from bridge watch duties, Harrington immediately shifted gears to his primary role as the Ship's First Lieutenant. He sprinted down the ladders to the humid weather decks to directly oversee the complex deck recovery and rescue operations of the men assigned.

The Deck Recovery

Then, the real-world friction of a night rescue began to assert itself. A CH-46 helicopter was still tied down on the flight deck from the earlier vertical replenishment (VERTREP) mission, its aircrew was already spinning up the turbines in accordance with man-overboard standard operating procedures. The high pitched, deafening whine of the aircraft engines created an acoustic wall on the deck, completely drowning out any cries from the water. Simultaneously, the heavy, structural roar of the ship's ventilation fans masked the ocean below. Harrington quickly coordinated to shut down the ventilation fans, and recommended that the bridge secure the helo, desperate to clear the airwaves so the recovery team could listen for the nearby sailor.

Realizing that the massive, rolling steel hull still posed a crushing hazard to a swimmer in the pitch black, Harrington chose not to risk pulling him directly up the side of the ship. He requested the ship to maintain its position several meters away, allowing the motor whaleboat—which had already been manned and prepared in the davits—to lower away and maneuver into the quiet starboard pocket. The whaleboat crew executed the final pickup flawlessly, hauling a wet, exhausted, but completely uninjured Seaman Swedlund out of the water.

The Rest of the Story

It was only after the successful recovery of the victim that the full, bizarre story of the incident was finally revealed to the Captain, Harrington and the bridge team. On the Shasta, lifesaving gear was normally stored in the after mooring station, where the aft lookout is positioned directly below the flight deck during helo operations. Once flight ops concluded, naval protocol dictated that the aft lookout reposition to the aft flight deck, bringing all the heavy rescue equipment along with them.

However, the off-going lookout had failed to bring the gear up. Because the gear could be seen plainly from the flight deck through the safety nets, and retrieving it meant navigating a tortuous, exhausting shipboard route. Walking half the length of the ship forward, heading down one interior deck, and then doubling all the way back just to reach a spot directly below where he had started, Seaman Swedlund decided to take a dangerous shortcut. He climbed over the horizontal safety netting at the extreme stern to pull the heavy gear up directly before assuming the watch.

His grip failed. Before slipping backwards into the black void, he looked at his stunned shipmate and uttered a chilling, brief final sentence: "Might as well call man overboard, I can't hold on."

The Aftermath

In the quiet aftermath of the flawless evolution, Commander John Kipp called Harrington aside in his cabin. The Captain admitted that under any other circumstances, Harrington would have been formally put forward for a Navy Commendation Medal for his superb, decisive ship handling. However, because

Swedlund was a member of Harrington's own watch team, filing the official paperwork would highlight a major safety breach and look unfavorable on the command's safety record.

It mattered little to Harrington. The ultimate prize was a living sailor safely back on deck. As for Seaman Swedlund, Harrington knew that once the Captain had finished taking his official "piece of flesh" at Captain's Mast, the unwritten laws of Navy discipline would take over. As an officer, Harrington would never dream of questioning or inquiring into what actions were taken by the Navy's Chiefs. Whatever re-education awaited the young lookout behind the heavy curtains of the Goat's locker was left entirely to the imagination, but everyone on board knew the Swedlund who emerged would be a much wiser, sharper sailor.

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